MASTERCLASS 1 · 20 NOVEMBER 2026 · FOUNDERS HOUSE

Know Enough.

Bookkeeper, lawyer or ops hire: what does your business need now, and next?

Format	Live, 60 minutes including questions. Modular: extends to 90 minutes or a paid version
Audience	Founders, roughly pre-seed to Series A, 5 to 40 people. No course needed beforehand
Presenter	Mila Milićević · NexaStrategic
Materials	26 slides, plus the Know Enough Map (sent 48 hours ahead)

DRAFT · PLAN AND SCRIPT

1. The spine

The question. Bookkeeper, lawyer or ops hire: what does your business need now, and next?

The thesis. You don't need to be the operator. You need to know enough to know when. Mila is the Swiss Army knife: a bit of every panel, and exactly where her limits are. Founders don't need to become that. They need enough operating literacy to see the whole ball, know what their business needs now and next, and know when to bring someone in and what to ask.

The two tests. *Now:* the house isn't on fire. I understand what's happening, and the company can exist. *Next:* if I stepped away, what breaks, and where would we still need a person's judgement?

The pivot. A business moves from Now to Next when it has paying clients in a clear customer profile and comfortable runway. From then on it needs a written strategic plan, and every panel answers to it. This is Mila's judgement, and two classic models back it. Churchill and Lewis's five stages of small business growth (Harvard Business Review, 1983): at the "success" stage, an economically healthy business chooses between staying stable and committing to growth. Greiner (Harvard Business Review, 1972): organisations grow through calm periods broken by crises, and what works in one phase becomes the problem in the next.

The thread. Kestrel, a fictional 35-person company built from Mila's real engagements, runs through the whole hour.

What founders leave with. A Know Enough Map scored Now and Next, one red picked, and a four-part brief to send that week.

Run sheet (60 minutes)

Time	Part	Slides	Goal
0–7	Open	1–5	What is operations? The ball, the knife, the thesis, the not-advice line
7–13	Kestrel, Now and Next, the pivot	6–9	The two tests and when to move between them
13–37	Three panels: people, finance, legal	10–18	Kestrel's story, then Now, Next and who could help; the room scores each row
37–39	Can't I just use AI?	19	Answer the most common objection
39–50	The brief	20–22	Four parts, then a live rewrite of Kestrel's brief
50–53	This week and close	23–25	One red, one brief, sent
53–60	Questions	26	Open floor

If time slips, cut the "too early" slide (9) and the AI slide (19). Never cut the brief. The 90-minute and paid versions add commercial as a fourth panel, live feedback on attendees' own briefs, and longer questions.

Guardrails

The not-advice line is said once, at the flip (slide 5), and printed on the map. Mila shows how to ask, never when someone needs legal, tax or financial advice. Triggers are tied to the business (runway, clients, headcount, contracts), not to the founder's mindset, which is David's ground. No firms are named. The audit trigger (slide 18) is presented with Mila's interest declared. Kestrel is labelled fictional. Stories from real engagements are anonymised, with sectors changed and numbers rounded. Nothing said by Founders House members is reused elsewhere without consent.

2. Why this, and how it was tested

The market. Most operations masterclasses for founders sell “get the founder out of the way”, or values-to-process frameworks. MasterClass, the company, has business classes from well-known leaders, but I found no operations class. Its format is about 20 lessons of 10 to 12 minutes with a workbook. Its strength is the instructor’s own career stories; the criticisms are passive learning and “inspiration rather than a skill set”.

How Know Enough is different. It’s active (founders score the map and write a brief), precise (the question to ask, the smallest step first), practitioner-led, and monthly, so founders come back and re-score. A paid version sells an outcome (a scored map, a briefed red, feedback from Mila), not content, because MasterClass anchors what people expect to pay for content low.

The council. The spine went through two reviews by four advisory lenses: operator, sceptic, strategist and a founder in the audience. They agreed on the following:

- the thesis
- Now and Next taught live, with Later left to the map
- one composite company as the thread
- modular timing with the brief protected
- “oversold”, never “swindled”
- no pitch

The gap is in what was found, not proven. A one-question poll of Founders House members would confirm which framing they’ll show up for.

3. Slide by slide

For each slide: what's on it, the **message** (the one thing it says), the **goal** (what it should do to the room), and the script. The script is a starting point to say in your own words. *[Brackets]* mark what you need to add.

Open (7 minutes)

1 COVER

Founders House · Masterclass · 20 November · Know Enough. · Bookkeeper, lawyer or ops hire: what does your business need now, and next? · Mila Milićević · NexaStrategic

Message Know Enough: what your business needs now, and next.

Goal Set the question; the map is already in their hands.

> 60 minutes. Open (7 min), Kestrel and the pivot (6), three panels (24), can't I use AI (2), the brief (11), this week and close (3), questions (7). The Know Enough Map went out 48 hours ahead; ask everyone to have it in front of them.

2 WHATIS

A question first · What is operations?

Message Most founders think operations is process.

Goal Get the room talking and surface the misconception.

> Ask the room and take three or four answers. Most founders say systems, processes, SOPs, admin. Agree that's part of it. Then: "That's one panel. There are eight."

3 BALL

Operations is · One ball. Eight panels. · Process · People · Commercial · Finance Legal · Compliance · Governance · Risk

Message Operations is one ball with eight panels; process is one of them.

Goal Give them the whole picture once. The heart image lives here.

> Process is one panel. Operations is the whole ball: process, people, commercial, finance, legal, compliance, governance, risk. It's the heart of the business: it keeps everything else alive. Bigger companies cut it into rev ops, fin ops, legal ops, and each team sees only its own colour. Tonight we look at the ball from a founder's seat.

4 KNIFE

How I work · A good operator is a Swiss Army knife. · A bit of everything. And exactly where my limits are.

Message This is how I work: a bit of everything, and I know my limits.

Goal Your credibility, shown as how you work.

> I know enough about every panel to spot a problem and to know what good looks like. And I know exactly where I stop. When I go to a lawyer, I don't ask them to tell me everything; I ask one question. Knowing the edges is the skill.

5

FLIP

You don’t need to be the operator. You need to know enough to know when.

Message You don’t need to be the operator. Know enough to know when.

Goal The thesis. Then the not-advice line, once.

> Pause. Your job as a founder isn’t to become the operations person. It’s to know enough to see the whole ball, recognise what your business needs now and next, and know when to bring someone in. Then, one sentence: nothing tonight is legal, tax or financial advice. It’s judgement about when to ask, and how.

Kestrel, Now and Next, and the pivot (6 minutes)

6

KESTREL

Meet Kestrel · fictional, built from real businesses · 35 people. Two years old. Paying clients. Just raised.

Message Meet one company we’ll follow all session.

Goal One thread that ties the panels together.

> Kestrel is fictional, a composite of businesses I’ve worked with. It has a product, a clear customer, paying clients and fresh funding. On paper, it’s doing everything right. We’ll follow it through the session.

7

NOWNEXT

The test · NOW · The house isn’t on fire. · I understand what’s happening, and the company can exist. · NEXT · If I stepped away, what breaks? · And where would we still need a person’s judgement?

Message Now: the house isn’t on fire. Next: if I stepped away, what breaks?

Goal Give them the two tests that structure the map.

> Two tests, one for each horizon. Now: the house isn’t on fire. You understand what’s happening and the company can exist. Next: if you stepped away for a month, what would go wrong? Even with the best systems and automation, where would you still need a person, because it needs judgement nobody in the business has? Every row on your map has a Now column and a Next column. *[Your argument, as yours: the black book. Historically, senior people mentored a successor and handed over their black book before retiring. With retirement ages rising and pensions less certain, many now hold on to it, and the handover doesn’t happen. A business has the same problem when one person holds the clients, the passwords or the know-how. That’s what the step-away test finds.]* Backed by: researchers call this knowledge hiding, deliberately withholding knowledge someone has asked for, and found it is predicted by distrust (Connelly and colleagues, Journal of Organizational Behavior, 2012); later studies link it to job insecurity.

8

PIVOT

The pivot · From surviving to a written plan. · Paying clients in a clear market. Comfortable runway. Now the question is growth. · Backed by · Churchill and Lewis, five stages of small business growth (HBR, 1983) · Greiner, how organisations grow (HBR, 1972)

Message You move to Next when you have paying clients in a clear market and runway; then you need a written plan.

Goal Your judgement, backed by Churchill and Lewis (1983) and Greiner (1972).

> My view: you move from Now to Next when you have paying clients in a clear customer profile and comfortable runway. From that point, the business needs a written strategic plan, and every panel needs to answer to it. That's my judgement from what I've seen, and two classic models back it. Churchill and Lewis (Harvard Business Review, 1983) describe five stages of small business growth: existence, survival, success, take-off and resource maturity. At the success stage, a business that is economically healthy has to choose: stay stable, or commit to growth. That choice is the pivot. Greiner (Harvard Business Review, 1972) found that organisations grow through calm periods broken by crises, and that what works in one phase becomes the problem in the next. The founder doing everything works at Now; it's the crisis at Next. Kestrel reached the pivot and didn't write the plan.

9

TOOEARLY

And the other way round · Operations can't fix a product with no market. · Now comes first.

Message Operations can't fix a product with no market.

Goal Stop anyone jumping to Next too early.

> *[Your story, anonymised: the early-stage platform in a high-risk regulated space where you de-risked everything, but it still had no market presence.]* I called it putting a plaster on a leak. Operations can make a business safe and ready, but it can't create demand. If you haven't found your market, Next can wait; get Now right first.

Three panels (24 minutes)

10

P2

Three panels · People. Finance. Legal. · Now, Next, and who could help. Fill in your row as we go.

Message Three panels, eight minutes each.

Goal Set the pace and the pattern.

> About eight minutes each. For each: what happened at Kestrel, then Now, Next, and who could help, starting with the smallest step. The other five panels are on your map.

11

PEOPLE STORY

Kestrel · People · Kestrel hired its way to ten times the size, with no hiring roadmap. · Teams duplicated each other. Niche roles multiplied. When funding tightened, there were redundancies.

Message Hiring without a roadmap ends in duplication and redundancies.

Goal Make the cost of skipping Next real.

> *[Your story: the scale-up you joined at about 35 people. No workforce plan, duplicated and very niche roles, and redundancies once investor funding was cut. Keep it anonymised and the numbers rounded.]* Nobody did anything wrong on any single hire. There just wasn't a plan the hires answered to.

12

PEOPLE

Panel 1 of 3 · People · Now · Contracts and right-to-work checks. · Payroll and pensions running. · Everyone knows their role. · Next · A hiring roadmap tied to the plan. · Every new role answers: why this, why now? · Who could help: · Payroll provider → HR adviser → People lead

Message Now: contracts, payroll, roles. Next: a hiring roadmap tied to the plan.

Goal They score their people row.

> Now: contracts and right-to-work checks for everyone, payroll and workplace pensions running, everyone knows their role. UK basics; a professional confirms the specifics. Next: a hiring roadmap tied to the strategic plan. Step-away test: if you were gone for a month, would anyone know who to hire next, and why? Who could help, smallest step first: a payroll provider, an HR adviser, then a people lead. Score your row: Now and Next, red, amber or green.

13

FINANCE STORY

Kestrel · Finance · Kestrel's hiring outran its money. · Every hire made sense on its own. Nobody had modelled what happens if the next round is late.

Message Every hire made sense; nobody modelled the late round.

Goal Connect people to money.

> The money side of the same story. Payroll grew faster than the plan, because there wasn't a plan, and there was no 'what if' case. *[Your detail, if any.]*

14

FINANCE

Panel 2 of 3 · Finance · Now · Books up to date every month. · You know this month's cash. · Next · A 12-month cash plan. · A 'what if the round doesn't come' case. · Who could help: · Bookkeeper → Accountant → Finance director, part-time → CFO

Message Now: books and this month's cash. Next: a 12-month plan with a contingency case.

Goal They score their finance row.

> Now: books up to date every month, and you know this month's cash. Next: a 12-month cash plan with a contingency case: what happens if the next round is late or smaller? Who could help, smallest step first: a bookkeeper, an accountant, a part-time finance director, a CFO. Most businesses at this stage need the first two done well. Not financial advice: the point is knowing which conversation to have. Score your row: Now and Next, red, amber or green.

15
LEGAL STORY

Kestrel · Legal · A possible data incident. Specialists offered a full audit. · One precise question to a large firm got a step-by-step answer instead.

Message One precise question beat a full audit.

Goal The ‘don’t get oversold’ story, told carefully.

> *[Your story, anonymised and told carefully.]* We had a possible data incident. Several specialists wanted to come in and run a full audit. We asked one large firm one question: what are the steps, in order, and what happens in the worst case? We got a step-by-step answer. The lesson is the precise question. One fact founders must know: with personal data, the clock matters. Under UK GDPR, if a breach is likely to put people at risk, it must be reported to the ICO within 72 hours of becoming aware of it. So the first question to a specialist is whether it’s reportable, today. Don’t tell this story in a way that sounds like avoiding that clock.

16
LEGAL

Panel 3 of 3 · Legal · Now · Core contracts signed and read. · Data protection basics in place. · Next · A plan for when something goes wrong. · You know who you call first. · Who could help: · Templates → Solicitor, one question → Specialist

Message Now: contracts read, data basics. Next: a plan for when it goes wrong.

Goal They score their legal row. You show how to ask, not when to take advice.

> Now: your core contracts are signed and you’ve read them, and data protection basics are in place. Next: a plan for when something goes wrong, including who you call first. Who could help, smallest step first: good templates, a solicitor for one question, a specialist when it’s their area. I won’t tell you when you need legal advice; that’s for a solicitor. I’ll show you how to ask. Score your row: Now and Next, red, amber or green.

17
ISLANDS

Kestrel · The whole ball · Every team its own island. · Rev ops, fin ops, legal ops. Operations was called in when things broke.

Message When operations is split into islands, nobody sees the whole ball.

Goal Bring the ball back.

> *[Your story: a small operations team, while rev ops, fin ops, legal ops, marketing ops and event ops each worked alone. You were deployed when something went wrong: “Can you go and figure out what’s going on?”]* That’s the ball cut into colours. Nobody saw the whole thing until it broke.

18
AUDIT

The last trigger · When you can afford it, get the whole ball looked at. · A neutral operator, an audit, and a view of what’s missing. Take it or leave it.

Message When you can afford it, have the whole ball looked at.

Goal The last trigger, with your interest declared.

> Say plainly that this is the kind of work you do, so nobody thinks it’s hidden. My view: once you have the free cash to bring in a contractor, have a generalist operator audit the business first. You get a report: where you are, what’s missing, what’s siloed, what I’d recommend. Feedback is an opinion, and you don’t have to take it. Founders often don’t enjoy being audited. It’s still the cheapest way to see the whole ball before it costs you.

Can’t I just use AI? (2 minutes)

19
AI

“Can’t I just use AI?” · Use it. You can’t delegate judgement. · It gives you an answer. It can’t tell you what it’s missing. · Backed by · Airline network planning: whole teams decide whether to open a route. SAS’s planning lead says the work is still largely human, with AI starting on forecasting.

Message AI gives you an answer; it can’t tell you what it’s missing. Knowing what’s missing is how you know who to bring in.

Goal Answer the most common objection with your story, backed by how airlines plan routes.

> The pushback I hear most. Use it: the teams I work with use Claude, ChatGPT and every automation we can. But an answer is only as good as your ability to push back on it. *[Your story, anonymised: no company or person named. Years ago I flagged what I thought was a data breach to a general counsel. She told me privately that my read was valid, then taught me something I couldn’t have known: in her experience you describe it as a possible or suspected breach while you investigate, because under UK GDPR the 72-hour reporting clock runs from when you become aware, meaning reasonably certain, that a breach has happened.]* Make clear the lesson is about precision and moving fast, not about delaying: once you’re reasonably certain, the clock runs. That nuance came from years of specialist experience. AI wasn’t in everyday use then, and even now you’d only catch something like that if you know enough to say: I don’t think that’s right, or you’re missing something. Knowing what’s missing is exactly how you know who to bring in. Backed by: airlines. Every airline has a network planning team whose job is deciding whether to open a route: forecasting demand, weighing competition, and judging how the route feeds the rest of the network, sometimes opening one that loses money at first for longer-term presence. SAS’s head of network planning describes the work as still largely human-driven, with AI starting to help on demand forecasting and scheduling. If an airline with all that data still relies on people’s judgement, so should you.

The brief (11 minutes)

20
P3

The brief · Ask one precise question.

Message Knowing who to call is half of it.

Goal Move from knowing to asking.

> About 11 minutes. Knowing who to call is half of it. The other half is what you say when you call. That’s how Kestrel got a step-by-step answer instead of an audit.

21
BRIEF

Not this · “Can you have a look at our data situation?” · This · The problem, in one line. · The decision I need. · What’s out of scope. · A fee cap, and by when. · Backed by · Locke and Latham: specific goals beat “do your best” (American Psychologist, 2002)

Message A good brief has four parts.

Goal A tool they’ll use next week, backed by goal-setting research.

> Backed by: Locke and Latham’s review of 35 years of goal-setting research (American Psychologist, 2002) found specific goals consistently beat “do your best”, because a vague instruction gives people nothing to measure against. A vague brief is “do your best” for a specialist. A vague brief gets a big answer and a big bill. Four parts: the problem in one line, the decision you need to make with their answer, what you are not asking for, a fee cap and a deadline. This is the back of your map.

22
REWRITE

Your turn · Kestrel’s brief · “We need some help with HR.” · Rewrite it. Problem, decision, scope, fee cap.

Message You can do this in two minutes.

Goal Practise on Kestrel, not on anyone’s own business.

> Live, about 6 minutes. Use Kestrel, not anyone’s own situation: nobody has to share their business in front of the room. Ask for rewrites, take two or three, improve one together. A strong answer: “Funding is tighter and we have overlapping roles in two teams. We need to know the fair process for a restructure before we decide whether to start one. We don’t need a handbook or policies. Fixed fee, answer by Friday.”

This week and close (3 minutes)

23
THISWEEK

This week · Finish your map: Now and Next. · Pick one red. · Write the brief. · Send it.

Message Finish the map, pick one red, write the brief, send it.

Goal One action.

> Finish every row of the map, Now and Next, red, amber or green. Pick one red. Write the brief on the back. Send it this week, to the smallest right person on the ladder.

24
CLOSE

Know enough to know when.

Message Know enough to know when.

Goal The line they repeat.

> You don’t need to be the operator. You need to know enough to know when to bring one in, who, and what to ask. Read it, and stop.

25
NEXT

Where to go next · Operations Fundamentals. · The whole ball, one panel at a time. Start with OF101.

Message The course takes the whole ball.

Goal One next step.

> One line, then stop. *[Add how founders join.]*

Questions (7 minutes)

26
QUESTIONS

Questions · Questions. · Mila Milićević · NexaStrategic

Message Open floor.

Goal Hear which panels are red at Next.

> About 7 minutes. If questions are slow to start: which panel is red for you at Next?

4. Before the day

1. **Anonymise the stories.** The scale-up (slides 11, 13, 17), the possible data incident (15) and the early-stage platform (9). Change the sectors, round the numbers, and leave out anything David or a member could recognise.
2. **Tell the data incident story carefully.** The lesson is the precise question. Don't frame it as avoiding calling something a breach. Under UK GDPR, a personal data breach likely to put people at risk must be reported to the ICO within 72 hours of becoming aware of it. The ICO's guidance is under review following the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025, so check the live page before the day.
3. **The general counsel story (slide 19).** Name neither the company nor the person. Frame it as precision and speed: "possible breach" while you investigate, and once you're reasonably certain the 72-hour clock runs. Don't say AI "didn't exist" in 2022; say it wasn't in everyday use. If two data stories (slides 15 and 19) feel repetitive, swap the legal panel story for another.
4. **Have an accountant and a solicitor sense-check the map.**
5. **Send the map 48 hours ahead.** Add how founders join the course (slide 25).
6. **Check the boundary with David.** The pivot is kept operational, but confirm he's comfortable with it. Confirm IP in the materials stays with you (decision d07).

5. Evidence bank

The argument is Mila's: her judgement, from what she has seen. These are the references that back it. Each one is said as "backed by", never as proof.

Claim	Backed by	Where it's used
Now to Next is a choice point, not a date	Churchill and Lewis, five stages of small business growth (HBR, 1983): at the success stage, stay stable or commit to growth	Slide 8, the pivot
What works at Now becomes the problem at Next	Greiner, Evolution and Revolution as Organizations Grow (HBR, 1972): growth phases end in crises; each phase's solution becomes the next one's problem	Slide 8; slide 17, the islands
The black book: people hold on to knowledge when they feel insecure	Knowledge hiding: deliberate concealment of requested knowledge, predicted by distrust (Connelly and colleagues, Journal of Organizational Behavior, 2012); later studies link it to job insecurity. Mila's argument about rising retirement ages is her own.	Slide 7, the step-away test
A precise brief gets a better answer	Locke and Latham, 35 years of goal-setting research (American Psychologist, 2002): specific goals consistently beat "do your best"	Slide 21, the brief
Judgement can't be outsourced to tools	Airline network planning: dedicated teams decide whether to open a route (demand, competition, network fit). SAS's network planning lead describes the work as still largely human, with AI starting on forecasting.	Slide 19, AI
Simple standards beat expertise alone	The WHO surgical safety checklist study (Haynes and colleagues, NEJM, 2009): across eight hospitals, complications fell from 11.0% to 7.0% and deaths from 1.5% to 0.8%. It was a before-and-after study, so it shows association, not proof.	Not in the 60-minute version; for the process panel or a future masterclass

6. Future masterclasses

This is a monthly series. Each session answers one founder question, and all of them feed into Operations Fundamentals.

1. **Steal the lessons, not the bureaucracy.** What founders can take from big organisations, and what to leave behind: how airlines decide on a route, surgical checklists, and succession and the black book (Mila's argument on retirement, mentorship and handover).
2. **How much can I build myself?** The minimum in each panel on a budget, and where doing it yourself becomes a false economy.
3. **What am I missing?** The compliance and risk panels founders don't see until something bites.
4. **Do I need an ops person yet?** The whole-ball trigger and what an audit looks like.

Sources

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Several pages were seen only as search listings; the luma.com and UCLA pages were blocked by the session's network settings.

NexaStrategic · Draft. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.